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Al Gallodoro — Part II

Al Gallodoro was born in Chicago on June 20, 1913. His virtuosity on the clarinet and saxophone has taken him from the vaudeville theaters of New Orleans to Carnegie Hall, and at age 92 he still enthralls audiences with his musicianship. He received an honorary degree from Hartwick College in September of 2005. Al was interviewed in Oneonta, New York on December 28, 2005. JoAnn Chmielowski, his pianist and manager, also participated in the interview, which was conducted by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

Funding for this interview was provided by members of the Hamilton College Class of 1956, in memory of their classmate, clarinetist Emerson Brown.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming today in Oneonta, New York. I am pleased to have Al Gallodoro, saxophone and clarinet virtuoso.

AG: Well I'm not quite the virtuoso that I was.

MR: Well, for many, many years. You're going into your eighth decade of playing. That's amazing. And I know you were honored recently by Hartwick.

AG: That's right.

MR: That's great. Honorary degree.

AG: Yeah, a doctor. This has never been done before, as far as I know. The only reason they gave me this is I started professionally before I was 14. I played in night clubs in New Orleans. I played about five years of big time vaudeville. Bob Hope, when he first started around 1930, 31, Milton Berle, Judy Canova. And I was playing classical. When I came to New York I was playing jazz, then in the theater, I've done every phase of the music business. And that is why I got this degree. I don't know of anyone that's done every phase of the music business like I have. Classical concertos on the clarinet, on the saxophone.

MR: You really have to have open ears for that kind of thing, don't you? And not have an attitude?

AG: No.

MR: Except for good music.

AG: Yeah. I loved music. I love all forms of music, except one and I won't mention.

MR: Okay. We may get to that later.

AG: No all professional musicians, great jazz guys, they scoff at that music. Well I won't say what it is.

MR: Well let me ask you about when you were in Chicago, as a boy, you said you recalled hearing a particular song that never left your memory. Remember we were just talking about that?

AG: A particular song?

MR: "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles?"

AG: Oh no, that was in Birmingham.

MR: That was in Birmingham.

AG: Well to be exact, it was a suburb of Birmingham. Thomas. T-H-O-M-A-S. Thomas is just a streetcar ride from Birmingham. And I've never forgot, there was an airplane with the tail, a flag, "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles." And I never forgot that. I must have been about eight, nine years old.

MR: Where did you hear music first? Was it from the radio or was it from 78s?

AG: Oh God, no we didn't have a radio. No. First it was my father. My father was a very good clarinetist. Not great like today, you know. Today they've gotten better and better and better. Like saxophones and flutes and oboes and whatever. We have progress, the instruments, it's amazing what we are doing today. But he played clarinet and I just happened to like it. And a funny thing, I wanted my father to start me off when I was five. He says, "No, ma boy," this is my biography, the television thing. He says, "You're too young to play the clarinet." And finally we were moving into Thomas, that's right, and I will never forget this. My father and mother they were putting the mattress together and so forth. They got the mattress. My father goes and gets a clarinet. He says, "Now giruono colino" (now I'll give you the clarinet). And that's how he started me off. He never had to force me to play, practice, no. I did it all myself. I loved it. I loved it. That was my joy.

MR: Were you one of those kids who would rather practice than play baseball?

AG: That's right. Oh that's right. Oh gosh yes.

MR: And I understand your brother played also?

AG: Yeah, both brothers, Peter and Frank. Frank is still alive. He lives in Riverside, California. He still plays whatever is left of the music business. He did the same thing I did, the Whiteman band, the circus, the ice shows and so forth.

MR: Was there sibling rivalry between you guys?

AG: No, no, no. Oh never, never. We respected each other. I never picked on my brothers because they couldn't play what I play, no. There was nothing like that, like the Dorsey brothers? Oh no.

MR: Oh yeah. No fist fights over the music. That's great.

AG: No. Never.

MR: When you were playing in some of the theatres in New Orleans, was this prohibition at the time?

AG: That is right. There were speakeasies. That's right. You had to knock on the door and — spiked beer. You know? Near beer, and then they put the alcohol in, a hundred percent, oh my goodness.

MR: But you were a teenager, right?

AG: Yes. I went into the Orpheum in 1928. What was I fifteen, fifteen and a half? Yes. Howard Tifft — T-I-double F-T. He graduated from Eastman School of Music incidentally. He was a piano player and a very good pianist. He loved to drink. And one night, this was before I was married, we went out in a speakeasy and we were drinking straight alcohol. It was beer or something. I never forgot that, yup. Those were the days.

MR: And then you had to go home after that. Did your parents get hip to the fact that —

AG: No, no. My parents were good. They were okay.

MR: I'm curious about some of the vaudeville acts that you played for. Did you get to — could you see them performing while you were playing or were you in the pit?

AG: Yes. We were in a pit, but we could look up on the stage. Bob Hope, he played his act twice, around 1930 and then he came back in '31. Milton Berle. The Ritz Brothers. They were famous. The Canovas — Judy, Zeke and Ann. Two sisters and a brother. Not Houdini.

MR: But some magicians?

AG: Yeah. A big magician, I think his son — I can't think of his name at the moment, not Jackson — or Cardini.

MR: Corgini?

AG: Cardini uses to come on with lit cigarettes from all over. I never figured out how he did it.

MR: He had lit cigarettes?

AG: Yeah. Then on occasion they had a unit, like the California Collegiates, and all we played was the overture and for 45 minutes we did nothing. We went downstairs and played poker or whatever, and we'd come back. And I'll never forget this. The famous tune that they came out with, and JoAnn my accompanist knows and we play it on occasion, was "The Hour of Parting." It was written in 1928. "The Hour of Parting." And the famous conductor at the music hall — now see how my mind skips me now — the famous conductor, he was great. He opened the music hall. Erno Rappe. Erno Rappe. Now today that means nothing to anyone. He was a great musician, great conductor. And when I went into the Center Theater Ice Show "It Happens on Ice," he opened the show as a conductor. Then he handed it to David Mendoza, who was the real conductor. But he

broke the show in, Erno Rappe. Yeah. And his son was a pretty good saxophone player. Can I tell you something about his son?

MR: Sure.

AG: He played Selmer also. And I said, "Bob," I says, "you play nice, you get a good sound, but man your high notes are so flat." And this went on night after night. I said, "Let me try your horn." I apologized. I said, "It's not you, Bob, it's the horn." They were flat. They were known to be flat, some of the old cigar cutter. They were known to be flat. Then they made them, not in tune but they made them sharp. They didn't go right there to pitch you know. I spoke to Marcel Mule about that. He says I know they're sharp but better that way because it's easier to come down, and that's the truth.

MR: When you were playing for these shows at that time, in New Orleans, was it a segregated audience at the time?

AG: Oh that's a very good question. The Orpheum Theater had two balconies. I just played there three years ago when I played the clarinet festival. Oh yes. The Black people, way up there, way up there. The street car, dividing line, in the back. Oh yes.

MR: How about the performers?

AG: Beg pardon?

MR: Were there black performers as well as white performers?

AG: You know I don't remember any. Black face yes, like Al Jolson, but actual black I don't remember. And I have a good memory. I can't recall ever having a black performer on the stage at the Orpheum Theater in four and a half years that I was there.

MR: And each performer would have his own music, and the conductor would —

AG: That a good — yeah, they would send the music. Let's say that they were playing in Atlanta. Well they had to have two sets of music. While they're in Atlanta the next stop would be New Orleans, they would send the music a day ahead of time. And we'd rehearse and then finally five acts of vaudeville. You had jugglers, Japanese, you had song and dance, you had comedians. You know Bob Hope was funny.

MR: Really? He was funny?

AG: Can I tell you about Bob Hope?

MR: Please.

AG: Bob Hope we played twice. The second time he came around it was all fixed. He says, "Guys, I'm going to say this and I'm going to say that." All right. So he comes on stage and he says, "Hi you guys" in the pit. "Hi. Remember me? Don't you remember me? You sure? I was only here a year ago. Don't you remember I was here with that beautiful blonde?" "Oh hi ya Bob, yes." That's the truth.

MR: And people cracked up at that stuff, right?

MR: Did you do any animal acts? Did they have animal acts?

AG: At the moment I don't really recall.

MR: You were probably lucky.

AG: Would you know JoAnn? Do you remember? No I don't remember animal acts.

MR: How much did you make in those times?

AG: Oh, $84.95 a week.

MR: $84.95 a week.

AG: Yeah. But we played seven days a week. And if you asked for a day off, Joe Russo, the conductor, he would give you a dirty look.

MR: Really. But you were still a teenager.

AG: Yeah. I joined when I was fifteen and a half.

MR: Yeah. You were playing at night. And then how did you get up for school in the morning?

AG: Tell me more. Well I wasn't going to school. No I only went to high school about three months. That was the end of it.

MR: That's interesting so maybe like ninth grade or so? You got to ninth or tenth grade?

AG: Right. Well at that time it was eighth grade and then started first year. Yeah. But Howard Vorhees got me the job at the Forest Club. It was a gambling house. They didn't call them casinos then. And we would play for dancing and so forth while people gambled. And then he finally got me to go into the Orpheum Theater. He came the contractor. He says, "Kid, I'm going to get you here." And I started at the Orpheum Theater. Then after a while he got the job at The Frolicks night club, only a couple of blocks, where Louis Prima was. He was playing in another place. Oh the clubs were all over, live music you know, five, six, ten piece bands. And after the Orpheum at eleven o'clock, we'd go and play until five in the morning. And I'd be playing you know.

MR: At that time, in New Orleans, King Oliver and Louis Armstrong, those guys had already gone north.

AG: That's right.

MR: But was there still a sense that this was the hotbed of jazz?

AG: Oh yes, absolutely. But you know all the clubs — I can't think of all the band leaders and trumpet players — Al Marico was one of the great trumpet players there. They were all white, all white in the clubs.

MR: So there was nobody who kind of took that—

AG: But there was black section there. Earl Hines came in. I will never forget, on Rampart Street, one of the clubs there. Earl "Fatha" Hines. He came. But most of the clubs, LaVita was a famous club, the Roosevelt Hotel, and oh there was jazz all over.

AG: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Yeah. It must have been hard for you to see some of that devastation that happened with Katrina, having lived there for a while.

AG: We were always — the Italians and Birmingham and Inslee, we got along. There was no — But I have to tell you this story. It must have been early 1928. See I moved to New Orleans from Birmingham or Pensacola, Florida, October of '27. It could have been late '27 or early '28 the St. Charles Theater on St. Charles Street — there's an Avenue and a Street — The Paul Whiteman Band was coming through. And God I'm only about 15 years old, fifteen and a half years old. And I waited outside and who gets out of a cab? The Dapper Dan Paul Whiteman, dressed with the afternoon clothes and striped pants and all. I'm looking — I was too bashful to say anything. I finally went in the theater and Frankie Trumbauer was with the band, Bix Beiderbecke was with the band, Chester Hazlett was lead alto, Charlie Margulis. And anyway I just marveled at it. But what I want to say is back then, let's say 1928, who ever thought that in 1936 I would become the lead alto man in New York with Paul Whiteman? This was something was unbelievable.

MR: Why did you know — why was he sort of an idol for you at that time? Through radio or through purchasing his records or what?

AG: No. Records. We didn't have a radio. No. I come from a poor family. We did not have a radio. Through records.

MR: But you had a turntable or a phonograph.

AG: Yeah, that's right.

MR: And you wound it up.

AG: Exactly. My father bought me Rudy Wiedoeft records. Yes, Forbes Music in Birmingham, I'll never forget the first time I heard Rudy Wiedoeft play "Saxophobia" or "Valse Vanite," which I have on the thing — you have it. I did that live at NBC with the orchestra back around 1943, 44. And if I have to say so myself that's very good. Live performance. All my life, JoAnn can tell you, you rarely hear fluff. I was a perfectionist. Actually I was a perfectionist.

MR: How did you get home every day from these engagements in the evening in New Orleans. Did someone have to take you back and forth or did you take a cable car?

AG: Well yes, when I worked at the Forest Club, Howard Vorhees picked me up and took me back home. And let me tell you about that. The Coaglino family, they were in the tobacco business, and they had quite a few dollars. And Joe liked my playing. He says, "Al I'm going to take you to this trumpet player, he's a leader, I want him to hear you play." And he took, me to his house and I noodled, I forget what I played, and he said, "Kid I'm

money. A nickel for a pack of gum, nickel for a hot dog with the sauerkraut, yeah. So anyway we'd finish the job and he's taking me back home and he pats me and he says, "Kid, very good, I'm going to up you to fifty dollars a week." I couldn't believe it. This is the honest to God truth. I tell the story all the time the same. It's not something that I put in my mind to say all the time, no, no. But my memory, I just never forgot it.

MR: Well your parents must have said well, fifty dollars a week.

AG: Oh my God, I couldn't believe it.

MR: That's a lot more than some adults were making at the time, right?

AG: Yeah but then I got in a bad habit, the gambling houses, oh God. Yeah the gambling house. Shooting dice you know.

MR: You mean you were losing money as fast as you were making it?

AG: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: What was the game of choice at the time? Like blackjack or something?

AG: No I liked dice.

MR: Yeah?

AG: Dice. I'd win but you'll lose it at the end. You'll lose at the end. You're a big loser at the end.

MR: At the time did you say "I've got to get out of this?"

AG: Yeah.

MR: I mean how did you —

AG: Yeah I finally got out of it when I left New Orleans to come to New York. Matter of fact I'll never forget the day. July 3, 1933, Southern Railroad on Canal Street.

MR: Really.

AG: That's when I took the train. I had fifty dollars in my pocket. I stopped at Knoxville, Tennessee to see the Pelicans, New Orleans Pelicans, play a double header. Don't ask me where I put my horns, where I checked them, and the conductor says, "Yeah son, you can get off and take the next train." I did this all myself. I was just 20 years old.

MR: And did have you have a specific destination?

AG: Yeah. New York. But I had to stop in Philadelphia first, because Danny Ryan, who was a trumpet player that I played with in a nightclub, he wanted me to go to New York with him. I says, "Danny, I'm not ready yet." But then when finally the theater closed, the Orpheum Theater closed, that's when I headed for New York, but I stopped in Philadelphia. I stopped in Philadelphia, this is good. I stopped at the rooming house and the lady came out, she says, "Oh Danny is not here, he is playing in Ocean City with Ray" (something band). I went to Ocean City and he was there and he says, "Al you remember Adrian Fleist, the cellist?" I said yes. He said, "He's playing with George

great singer. He is at the Ritz Carlton. Don't ask me how I got to Atlantic City from Ocean City, I must have taken a bus. I think what did we do, only 20 years old, we had no fear. And he was gone. George Olsen had gone. But at the Ambassador Hotel I see Isham Jones, oh my God, Isham Jones was a big name at that time. "It Had to be You," "I'll See You in my Dreams." And the story is the same. I went to the dining room and to the maitre d' I says, "Is it possible to see Mr. Jones?" He says, "Oh no, no, no, you can't see him but I'll send his manager." Arnold Frank. Arnold Frank was his name. And he says, "All right kid." Oh I bragged about how good I was, I had to, I had to get in. He says, "Come tomorrow afternoon" — this is good— and Jones is having a rehearsal. I had my baritone sax and my alto and clarinet. Don't ask me how I handled the baritone sax and the clarinet and sax coming all the way from New Orleans, stopping at Knoxville, oh I stopped in Washington. That's the first time I had ever eaten scallops. In those days Horn and Hardart had them in a pan. They were the most delicious things I had ever eaten you know. Well anyway —

MR: Was that what they called a cafeteria style?

AG: Yeah. It was a cafeteria. So anyway I came the next day and I played for Jones and he hired me. But the guys didn't like me. You know why they didn't like me? They wanted away from Jones, Jones hires me, he didn't need me, but he only used me to solo here and there. You know who was the arranger? He became big later. Gordon Jenkins. Gordon Jenkins was the arranger. So I stayed with him until let's say around July 7th or 8th, until after Labor Day. We toured all of New England with Jones. It was cold. There were no heaters in cars then. Finally we ended up in Manhattan. The Commodore Hotel. And that's where Jones — I said "Gitch." My nickname to him was "Gitch." Why he called me "Gitch" I don't know.

MR: He called you "Gitch?"

AG: Yeah "Gitch." I don't know where he got that from. That was always "Gitch." He says, "Kid I have to let you go." I says, "Why? Am I not good enough?" He says, "No, you don't belong to the union and you can't work a steady job until you are here for six months." They went into the Commodore Hotel and that's when they had to let me go. And then I moved around, lounged around 48th Street. Musicians were up and down the street and the cops would say, "Come on guys, break it up, break it up." And one thing led to another and you'd meet a piano player and you'd sit in or something and then he recommended me to Alfredo Antonini and Vincent Zorrie. They were the conductor and piano player at WRNS radio station. And I auditioned there and I got the job.

MR: Did you ever consider any other kind of work?

AG: No.

AG: No. Music was one hundred percent. Maybe a hundred and ten percent. No. I didn't care for anything else but to play that horn and perfect, perfect, perfect. 'Til this day she can tell you, ooh I get mad at myself sometimes.

MR: How much did it cost for a room for a week in New York at that time.

AG: Oh well with the Whiteman band hotel rooms were so reasonable. We used to get a rate. $2.50 single. Not the Waldorf, but good hotels. No flea bags. Like Goldie used to say, no flea bags you know. And it was great traveling with the band, the Whiteman band. And I'll never forget. See I joined spring of '36. But I was doing the radio show. Woodbury Hollow Soap Hour. And I just did that. The rest of the band, they were doing Jumbo. Billy Rose's Jumbo at the Hippodrome Theater, it was on Sixth Avenue just north of 42nd Street. The old Hippodrome. And they were doing that show. And every week I just did the broadcast. Adolph Deutsch was his main arranger. He finally went to Hollywood and made it big there. Ramona was in the band. I can tell you every musician that was in the band. Five saxes. Jack Cordero tenor; George Bandford from Boston, flute and tenor; Charlie Strickfaden oboe and baritone; Frankie Trumbauer and I sat next, together, and that was it, he was a wonderful guy and a wonderful player.

MR: What was he like? Was he friendly? Easy to get along with?

AG: Frankie? Oh God, he was a beautiful man. Beautiful. We admired each other you know. I have to tell you this story. In 1937 we went to Biscayne Kennel Club in Miami. The dog races.

MR: The greyhounds?

AG: The greyhounds. Biscayne Kennel Club. And I was playing, gambling, gambling, oh God. I said, "Frankie, I'm losing, can you loan me three hundred dollars? I want to get my money back." He peeled off three hundred dollars. So help me God, within a couple of nights I got all my money back and I quit. I never forgot that. Frankie was a great guy.

MR: He died pretty young, didn't he?

AG: Yes. The last time I saw him was 1948, we were on tour. And I saw him in Kansas City. That's where he ended up. He was a pilot you know. Yeah Frankie was great.

MR: When did you get into playing for soundtracks? Was that later, playing for television?

AG: Soundtracks. Like Terry Tunes, Loony Tunes?

MR: Yes.

AG: That came in the forties.

MR: Oh before we go there, touring with Whiteman, you guys traveled first class?

AG: Oh yeah.

MR: Trains and—

AG: Oh yes. We had our own car. There were times when we had to take a bus because there

MR: But when you were touring with Whiteman, was it a concert situation or were you playing for dancing?

AG: Yes. That's a good question. It was for dancing. But in the middle of the dance we'd stop and do a short concert. Maybe a half hour. And we always played the "Rhapsody in Blue." And JoAnn has that written down. How many times did I play? We would always, ninety-nine percent of the time, start right from the clarinet slide. There were occasions when he started with the theme but very rare. And then we went back to dancing. And those were the days when the audience used to stand right in front of the band.

MR: You guys probably had to look very sharp in those days, tuxedos?

AG: Oh, tell me more. Uniforms absolutely. We had two or three uniforms. Yes. We had about three. Two tails, like blue and yellow, and then short. Oh yes. In those days everybody dressed well, Monk. Everybody. We used to joke in rehearsal — where my brother bought his suit. I said, "Frank, where did you get that?" "Oh Phil Cronfeld." Phil Cronfeld was on Broadway. That was a real man's shop. And then you had Laten's. There was no shagginess in those days. No.

MR: Well you know it's interesting because we were talking earlier about our mutual friend Joe Wilder.

AG: Uh huh.

MR: And he reminds me of that because you never see him not with a suit and tie.

AG: That's right. That's a perfect example right there. Yeah we always admired each other's clothes. And in those days the big cities had the good men's suits. Chicago, New York, Philadelphia, Boston. Today the whole thing is stage. You can go in J.C. Penney and get a beautiful suit, whatever, you know. Oh yes.

MR: What was Whiteman like as a disciplinarian. Did he have to, like, correct behavior in the band if he didn't like things?

AG: No. He was very jolly. He was very jolly. No. He was fine. No problems there.

MR: Was traveling on the road kind of a tough life though?

AG: No I loved it. I loved it. I was strong. Because see, being a Gemini, I always like to travel. I like to go to different cities. And to me it was always a joy. And many nights we didn't get too much sleep. Many nights we'd play poker on the train. You'd have a berth to go sleep in, eight hour trip, and we'd play for six, seven hours. Oh yes. Roy Bargy was the piano, conductor and arranger. He was great. He was a great man.

MR: Were you worried about your future at all when the Whiteman era came to an end for you?

AG: No. No. As a matter of fact I took a couple of months off. I took my family to New Orleans. He disbanded Memorial Day of 1940. Akron, Ohio. We were playing at dog

family, stayed there, and I got a telegram Whiteman wanted to join Fred Waring, but I declined. I don't know what happened.

MR: Well you'd had enough of that particular —

AG: Well I was confused. I didn't know what I wanted to do you know.

MR: Did you do the military? Did you do military service?

AG: No. No I didn't go in. I had turned 40.

MR: Okay.

AG: Or 30. I had turned 30 and that's why. And then I had four children at the time. And oh God, well anyway Sal Francella, who was my sidekick in the Whiteman band, he was also from New Orleans and we knew each other as young boys from New Orleans. He called me or something, he sent a telegram, he says, "I'm going into an ice show, and I can get you in." And I accepted it. That was October of 1940. "It Happens on Ice" at the old Center Theater. Well now, but they tore it down, anyway, I did that for a couple of years and I met Paul Lavalle, Joey Lucifano, and he asked me if I wanted to go into the NBC Symphony playing bass clarinet. And he arranged an audition for me, and even though I was very proficient on the bass clarinet, I had never actually read bass clef. And anyway I had my clarinet and my bass clarinet on the stage and who is up there? Toscanini. Dr. Frank Black. And the contractor, A.C. Spitalny. Leopold Spitalny. He was the big contractor at NBC. Dr. Frank Black was the big conductor also, and I played some of Tristan and Isolde, Wagner, and before you know it I got the job and that was it.

MR: And your family was already — you already had a place in New York?

AG: Oh yeah, I was living in Sunnyside at the time. Incidentally that was June of '42. See I went in the Center Theater October '40, and I left June of '42 to join the NBC Symphony.

MR: You know I wanted to ask you something about the 1930s. Did the depression affect you very much? The depression years?

AG: No. No that's a good question but it didn't. It didn't. There was a lot of work. Club work, bar mitzvahs, night clubs, outdoor parties, whatever. And all the radio stations had a band, even if it was a six piece band. And the networks all had 65 men except WOR, they had 45. The Don Lee Network. But there was plenty of work for musicians.

MR: It's like the entertainment didn't suffer as much as some of the other —

AG: Well a lot of theaters had closed, like, oh we had seven theaters in New Orleans with pit bands. Finally there were none. And same with New York and Chicago. But somehow I made it. I worked in what they call Yorkville, the German section of New York, 85th Street. I worked in a place there called the Gloria Palast — P-A-L-A-S-T — something like that. It was a small group, it was for dancing. I think we got about $35 for three

MR: Apiece.

AG: Apiece, yeah. And then I got in with the Lanin office and I'm doing gigs there. The scale at that time like for a five hour job was twelve dollars back in 1934, '33. Oh yeah, amazing.

MR: But there was no such thing, probably, as minimum wage back then.

AG: Well there was, a union scale.

MR: Oh yeah, but I mean in general, if you were a carpenter or something. So you were doing fairly well there.

AG:: Yeah that I don't know. But when I got into the WINS radio station the scale was eighty dollars. Seven days a week. And Antonelia says, "I'm going to get you five dollars more, eighty five dollars." I never forgot that.

MR: And everything was live, right?

AG: Yeah. You've heard of Ron Aldridge? He's a famous dentist and a great jazz clarinet player? Ron Aldridge. He plays very much like Buddy DeFranco. Well his father was a cellist and saxophone player with me at WINS at the time.

MR: I'll be darned.

AG: Yeah. Jimmy Aldridge. I remember Ron when he was just born.

MR: Did you have in those days, were you thinking about putting money aside for your retirement and all that.

AG: Yeah I did that.

MR: Did you?

AG: Yeah. I forget the insurance company at the moment, yeah Chicaine. Yeah I was putting in oh so much. I had my family, I had 50 thousand dollars on my life. And then after many, many years I gave it up. I couldn't afford to pay it anymore. I was spending too much.

MR: Well you got to be known as someone who could handle just about any kind of music that was put in front of you. You had that reputation.

AG: Oh God yeah that's a good question. You did call for a date and it didn't matter what the date was. I didn't get called so much for Dixieland or jazz, you know. I was not really known as a jazz player. I was an improviser. But you know the guy's jealous — oh he doesn't play like so-and-so, unless you sounded like Benny or Shaw you were no good. If you had your own style, you know. That's why Jimmy Dorsey wasn't too well known for his jazz clarinet playing, because he was different, he was entirely different.
[pause]

MR: I wanted to ask you about — you've played with an awful lot of great conductors.

AG: Oh yes.

AG: Stokowski. Well let me tell you about the two conductors. They used to alternate. One week on the broadcast Toscanini conducted. The next week Stokowski. And they alternated. Now we premiered the Shostakovitch Seventh Symphony. It can be bought. It was taken off the air. And I had to borrow a special bass clarinet that went down to the low C. Today they all go to the low C. So I was tipped off by the bassoon player, that Mike Guerra in Philadelphia, had one, it went to the low C. I called him and he says, "Yes I'll gladly loan it to you." And we did it with Toscanini. I had plenty of wind in those days, but still, down there, the wind was hard, you know? And Toscanini didn't budge, didn't budge. He just kept conducting. Six months later or so we repeated it with Stokowski playing. And he gets on the podium and he says, "Now bass clarinet and oboe, take your time, I'll wait for you." And it was much easier with Stokowski. He didn't rush you, you know? I never forgot that.

MR: That's nice.

AG: So actually we did it twice within six months. But the one with Toscanini is the one that they released. It can be bought.

MR: Tell me about Bernie Green. Sometimes he was Bernard Greenwald?

AG: Bernard Green yes. He was a very good conductor, very good arranger. He knew what he wanted and he got it. He was a wonderful guy. He was a little excited sometimes but nice you know. And God, we worked together for about ten years at ABC.

MR: His son told me that he used to say, "Al is the best."

AG: Yeah, yeah.

MR: He said that about you. And you did that album called "Musically Mad" was it?

AG: The "Mad" one, yeah. But the other one is "More Than You Can Stand."

MR: "More Than You Can Stand."

AG: Yeah. Ray Crisara, trumpet, Charlie Margulis, and a great xylophonist and timpanist, George Gaber. He is one of the greatest timpanist/percussionists in the world. He went to Bloomington, Indiana, thirty years ago. And he's still alive. He's there. He's one of the greatest. Things he could do with the timpanis you know, made different sounds. Yeah. George Gaber.

MR: When you did an album in those days, how long did it take to do an album?

AG: Well a session was three hours. But an album, no, that took more than three hours. It might have taken us all day. But it was "More Than You Can Stand." It's a long LP. That's where I play "Saxophobia." And then he wrote a piece called "Idyell" but it wasn't called anything. I'll tell you what happened. We used to do the Elgin Watch T.V. show and U.S. Steel Show. And in the studio Bernie had earphones on. And there's a love scene going on in the movie. And a violin is playing this beautiful background music. So

on that album "More Than You Can Stand," called "Idyell." Four clarinets and myself. It's very beautiful. It only runs maybe two and a half or three minutes.

MR: Is it I-D—

AG: I-D-Y-E-L-L. Idyell. Yeah.

MR: Did you used to do some kind of takeoffs on Wagner operas or something with him? On the Henry Morgan Show.

AG: Yeah, yeah. That might be in "Mad." And it might be in "More Than You Can Stand."

MR: They were like spoofs?

AG: Yeah. I'm pretty sure. One of those two. Henry Morgan was very funny, oh yeah. This Mad thing, the orchestra is fantastic. Absolutely fantastic. There again it's all funny, but legitimate playing. Oh yes. All legitimate playing. Fast tonguing, fast this and that. And I think most of the time he used Ray Crisara. Ray is still alive as far as I know. He teaches in Austin, Texas, at the University of Austin. I did a concert there in 1990, June of — no, 1980.

MR: When you — I'm going to leap ahead a little bit — but you've seen an awful lot of changes in this country: technology and social issues and all that. Are there certain things that stand out in your head as being really memorable and unbelievable changes over the years?

AG: Oh my God. Unbelievable is like I remember one instance, when tape recorders came out. There were wire. An actual wire. And the music was on the wire. But it sounded raspy. It was raspy. And shortly after that came the ribbon. And they got better and better and better. And now you can buy little boxes that have a wonderful sound. Yes. I know we didn't even have a phonograph. Yeah, I'm sorry I take that — we had the wind-up phonograph.

MR: But when I think of the 78s which we have some, and you had one song on each side.

AG: That's right.

MR: And they were heavy to carry around.

AG: That's right and they were scratchy. But some 78s were not as scratchy as others. My original recording of "Concerto for Doubles," I'm glad I'm thinking of this, we had a 50 piece orchestra. Manor. M-A-N-O-R. They were on 57th Street just west of Broadway or Eighth Avenue. Sam Lyra and his partner. Ralph Herman was arranging for the company for different singers, and Ralph said, "Why don't we do something different? Al Gallodoro just performed a 'Concerto for Doubles' that Paul Whiteman had written for him. Why don't we do this?" and a few other things, the "Fantasy Impromptu." Do you have that album by the way?

MR: Yeah. I think I do.

AG: You have it. Well we hired a 50 piece orchestra. We each put up $1,350. The session started right in Carnegie Hall at midnight. And we went until six in the morning. And I did the whole three movements of the "Concerto for Doubles." Alto sax, bass clarinet, clarinet. Then I did "Oodles of Noodles" and the "Fantasy Impromptu." But I was in my prime then. 50 piece orchestra. My brother Frank was in the band. And I went to the office one day and he gave me a check for about $240. He says, "I'm going to send Ralph his money" because Ralph went back to Milwaukee. That's where he was from, Milwaukee, Wisconsin. But Ralph never received any money. They were scoundrels, I'll tell you right now. They absconded with the money. They absconded with the original platter. Ralph could never get it back. Sam, Irving Berman was the other fellow. He was on the Unfair List for about two or three years in the New York Union newspaper. Unfair List. So that's the story on the "Concerto for Doubles." Well those records were a little scratchy. Now I have that in my "Many Sides." Do you have that? "The Many Sides of Al Gallodoro?"

MR: Yes. In fact I wanted to play just a brief thing here for you, okay? Let me see if I can get this piece up and perhaps you can tell me a little bit about it. We'll just listen to.

[Pause]

MR: I like that, you've got a little time to speak on the air.

AG: Yeah. That's on the CD.

MR: And I think what you had played was "Nola."

AG: That's right. Now listen to the bass player, he's out of time.

[Pause]

AG: This was released you know. They took it off the air.

MR: Well, as a saxophone player, I want to tell you, that that's impossible.

AG: Yeah.

MR: How did you do that? How did you learn to do that articulation?

AG: Oh, Howard Voorhees, the man that got me into the Orpheum Theater, and the Forest Club.

MR: Really? He showed you how to do that?

AG: Yes. I'll tell you what happened. Something went wrong with his embouchure and he couldn't play trumpet but he could play the saxophone. So he took up the saxophone, practiced and practiced, and he adopted the double and triple tonguing on the saxophone.

MR: I see. He used to do it on the brass instrument.

AG: Yeah. So he showed me what to do. And he said practice slow. Don't go for speed, the speed will come. Most everybody, they want to rush you know? Like play a passage and they'd rush. And I mean they flubbed, and they went on. I said, "Wait a minute, wait a

Because if you keep going you're going to make the same mistake every time. So that's why he told me he said get the sound. Make sure that the "coo" sounds like a too. And he told me how to do this. And I practiced slow and I practiced slower. And that's how it all came about.

MR: That's terrific. So we're going to take another pause and we'll bring JoAnn in here. [Pause]

MR: I'm pleased to be joined by JoAnn Chmielowski. And I got a little bit of insight about how this working relationship started, but I'd like to hear it again if you don't mind.

JC: Oh sure. This is above everything a symbiotic relationship because Al is the long term memory of his career and I'm kind of the short term memory. But really what I am is a kind of fan gone berserk. I met Al I guess — oh now my daughter is 17 — I met Al 16 years ago. He was playing in a restaurant that I was at. And I couldn't believe what I was hearing. And I said how could this be, in Oneonta, that there is such a musical quality like this. Because I'd been living here maybe about ten years, originally from the New York City area, Brooklyn. I worked in Manhattan and you know, so I was used to when you go see something it's like top notch. And I moved up here and things were quite good entertainment wise, but not like this. So I started talking to Al and he spoke the same dialect as my grandparents. And I said oh, I found a paisan. And we struck up a relationship like that. And I was working at the restaurant at the time. And one night the keyboard was unoccupied and I sat in. And jokingly he said to me, "Oh keep practicing, I'll hire you in a few years." And I didn't really think he was serious but you know with that thought in mind I just kept practicing. And I probably kept practicing for about six or seven years when he needed a keyboard player, piano player, for a wedding that was in a cornfield, literally in the middle of nowhere. The Scarpino wedding, right? We still have it on tape. So he figured well the people were from Virginia, the other side of the family were from Brooklyn, the cornfield was out in the middle of nowhere, and he said well this is a good time to take chance on this person because when she blows it it won't matter. So we were out there and we played and after that we were hooked. And I found that what I did was have this mission that had, oh my gosh, people have to know about this man. And it was just in the beginning of the Internet. And I had just gotten a computer. And I think without that tool it would have been really difficult for me to really promote Al and his things, and to do the writing that needed to be done for publicity without the word processor, because well I had a job, I had a young family, my children were little, so it because like kind of my mission.

MR: It's definitely the ways in which we can promote ourselves and others these days has changed rapidly and I'm glad that Al is here to take advantage of that and that you can

JC: Yeah because he said he didn't even have a radio. And now we have the Internet.

MR: Yeah. And now you're all over the Internet.

AG: I can't believe how this all came about. She is the one. She put me on the map. And of course I helped put her on the map too. But she is really, really — where would I be if I had not met her? I'd be doing a few gigs here and there. Now I'm known all over the world.

JC: Yeah. You know you were doing the other part of the interview and I think you got to 1926 or somewhere in there. But in 1951 Al recorded "Saxophone Contrasts" CD I mean album. And that probably has been the most requested on the Internet. Where can I get a hold of the recordings from "Saxophone Contrasts" "Saxophone Contrasts." That was 1951. And he followed it up in 1958 with another album "Gallodoro" was the title for your listening pleasure. We're not quite sure what the title of that one was, but that was in 1958.

MR: Was that something that Selmer had a hand in?

AG: Yes. That's right.

JC: And we're about to release those now, which is really cool. Because people have been asking for them, literally, for years.

AG: I'm trying to think of my wording. It'll come to me.

MR: Do you think that people when they come to hear Al play make an emotional connection?

JC: Oh yeah. It's gotten, it's grown exponentially. That over, since Al's gotten older, and is getting older and older and I'm make no bones about calling him old.

AG: Yeah.

JC: I don't feel bad about it because he is. But it just seems like as he's getting older people are reacting to his playing in a more emotional way, that a lot of times you have people, like, in tears. You know, just teary eyed. And they can't believe what they're hearing. And I think that for us baby boomers and people that are around our age group, it gives us some kind of like hope for ourselves that maybe we'll, well hopefully we can be in a place — it kind of shows people what you're capable of in old age. I think we're all looking for that as we age. So I think that's part of it. He's got a lot of young fans, and they just think, oh my gosh, you should see the girls in their twenties [screeches]. And I love it. And he does have a lot of fans of all ages.

MR: Yesterday I was listening to an interview with George Clooney. And he was talking about Rosemary Clooney, who was his aunt I think, and how she in her later career made different musical choices because her voice had changed a lot. Do you find that you need to make different musical choices when you're improvising now?

AG: Oh yes. Due to my arthritis. And she can tell you because we practice a lot. I thank God

blink of an eye I know, don't go that way. But you've got to be fast. You've got to be efficient with your technique. If you have a lot of technique and you lost most of it you still have enough left to take the other route. And she knows it. Now this is not egotism but a lot of the things I play better today than I used to.

JC: Yeah, your improvisation is —

AG: And my improvisation. Even I like what I do. Now that's not egotism, that's professionalism. When I say even I like it, that's means it's got to be good or I'll admit it's not good.

MR: Because you are a perfectionist, I can tell. Do you have any words of wisdom for JoAnn and I about longevity. Is there anything you think you've done in your life that —

AG: Positively. First of all I'm a fantastic eater. I love all foods. All foods. Name it, all kinds of meats, all kinds of seafood, raw oysters, raw mussels, raw clams. Pomegranates. Fruit. Vegetables. Fish. Three o'clock in the morning I'll make spaghetti, go to bed, no heartburn. Years ago I'd have heartburn, today I don't. But I have other obstacles. And I'm a vitamin freak. Always took a lot of vitamins, since 1934 and '35. And I think that has helped also. A lot of Vitamin E and so forth.

JC: But I think even more than all these things is you have something to do that you love. And I think that's the whole key to it.

AG: That's it, the horn. The famous words, "Hey Al are you still playing?" I say, "I am. Only the coffin will take me."

MR: Okay. What's coming up in the near future?

AG: Oh JoAnn you tell him. We just broke the ice.

JC: Okay here. Here I am with the short term memory, and I'm about to say, duh. Well actually there's a lot of things going on. We're about to release the "Saxophone Contrasts" album as a CD, which people have been looking for for a long time. We just released a different CD "The Infinite Gallodoro." What's real cool about it is for people that are interested in what we were talking about, like carrying forth into old age what you love to do. It has one CD of his playing today, which is recorded last summer, and the other CD is his older playing. So it's a kind of comprehensive type of thing. So we have those two things CD-wise in the works, plus all the other stuff that needs to get out there and get promoted. In terms of concerts coming up, Al will be in New York City at the Madison Avenue Presbyterian Church on April 2 at 3 P.M. And the orchestra is the Harmony Ensemble of New York.

AG: They're very good.

JC: Under the conductor Steve Richmond. And what Steve does is take old arrangements, what he's taking Paul Whiteman arrangements, and he's replicating them very

ago and Al did a recording with him of "Fascinating Rhythm" which was from an old Whiteman arrangement. And they also recorded the "Gallodoro Serenade" with Lincoln Mayorga on piano. It was written for Al by Ferde Grofe back in the 1950s.

AG: Yeah. Quite difficult.

JC: Only performed once.

AG: That's right.

JC: So this is really the New York City premier performance.

AG: Is it coming out soon?

JC: Yeah. Steve Richmond had told me that he's working on it now to get that on to CD. So there's a lot of different stuff. We perform a lot locally. We had Christmas parties, nursing homes, we'll be at Justin's in Albany and Cafe Lena in Saratoga. Al, hopefully, will be traveling somewhere. We're always working on stuff.

AG: Did you just mention Albany?

JC: Yeah.

AG: All right. Broke that ice. It's a famous place. Nick Brignola used to play there.

MR: Nick Brignola played there, yeah, a lot of people. So they deserve you.

AG: I have to tell you this story. JoAnn, you know it. "Saxophone Contrasts" I recorded Czardas Monti and Hora Staccato. Both excellent. Even I like it. Now I want you to understand what that means, even I like it. That is not egotism, that's perfectionism. When I say even I like it, I'm very particular with myself. Okay. Now seven years later they wanted me to do another album. And they wanted me to do the Hora Staccato and the Czardas again. I said man I did a beautiful job on the Columbia. I've got to do it both as well and faster. So nobody, none of the musicians can say, "Well Gallodoro sort of slowed up a little." No. You listen to both. They're going to be both on there. They are both a little faster and a little better. But I was in my prime.

MR: As that guy on the CD said from that radio broadcast, he said, "That was some mighty fine tootin.'"

JC: Yeah, I like that.

MR: I'm so thrilled to have this opportunity. I look forward to hearing about all your future appearances and so forth.

AG: Just let me say that all of the CDs there, you don't hear all of my playing. Because with the group that I had when I first met you at the Alley, I was playing different you know. But all-in-all, you can hear from jazz to classical. The Brahms "Clarinet Quintet" that was done live back in 1964. Live at ABC. It's just perfect as I could have gotten it even if I had gone into a studio. Oh yes. And the one I did in Florida with the 16-year-old boy.

MR: You know I don't know about you but in meeting a lot of well known musicians you sort

to get to know you guys and share some of the — it's not just musical knowledge, it's life knowledge I think.

AG: There's so many things, I'm sorry, so many things come to my mind and I have to say it before I forget it. When we recorded "Daybreak," here, what was it three years ago?

JC: 2001 I think.

AG: Yeah. Good. Oh the years that have gone by, oh my goodness, well anyway we did "Daybreak." You know Paul Whiteman brought that over from Germany. It was called "Madonna." But in those days that was too religious so they called it "Daybreak." So we recorded "Daybreak," and we recorded "When Day Is Done." But this beautiful lady, who has the brains, she says, "Al, we're going to open the thing with 'Daybreak' and we'll close it with 'When Day is Done." And that's exactly what we did.

MR: Well could I convince you guys to play a tune for me and for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive?

AG: Beg pardon?

MR: Would you play a tune for us today.

AG: Well I'll try. I practiced a little last night. And as you know I have a bad tooth. But I can manage.

MR: We'll pause for a second.

[pause]

JC: Great. Okay thank you, so much, Hamilton College Jazz Archive for having us part of you. And thank you. And I cannot believe how you played, after you talked for an hour and a half, two hours. Whoa. Good. Okay. Thank you.